Strategy-Relative Regime Switching as a Verifiable RLVR Environment for Financial Planning

Imen Ayadi

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Abstract

We introduce the first verifiable reinforcement learning with verifiable rewards (RLVR) environment for financial planning, designed for large language model (LLM) post-training. The environment is grounded in the strategy-relative regime switching framework of Bilokon (2026), where an agent makes binary switching decisions under an observable mean-reverting signal, subject to switching costs. We use the Ornstein-Uhlenbeck process to model signal dynamics, exploiting its Gaussian transition density for exact Bellman solutions via Gauss-Hermite quadrature — bypassing the fundamental obstacle that prevents RLVR in real financial markets (unknown distributions). A parameter landscape analysis across 1,500 configurations identifies signal persistence (κ) as the dominant factor determining when forward-looking planning diverges from myopic behavior (up to 22

1. Introduction

RLVR has transformed LLM post-training for math (DeepSeek-R1; DeepSeek-AI et al., 2025) and logic (Reasoning Gym; Stojanovski et al., 2025). But existing gyms test **static reasoning with complete information**: the model sees a full problem and produces one answer.

No gym tests **sequential decision-making under uncertainty** — where the agent acts before the full picture is revealed, each action has a cost, and the optimal strategy depends on future dynamics. Consider:

> **Math gym (static):** "The expected return is 0.105 and the fee is 0.15. Should you enter?" → One computation: no.
>
> **Our gym (sequential):** Same parameters, but the signal persists. Enter now, pay 0.15 once, earn returns for many steps. Whether to enter depends on *how long the signal will persist* — information requiring reasoning about dynamics, not just the current snapshot.

Financial planning faces a verification obstacle: real markets have unknown distributions, making optimal solutions uncomputable. We bypass this using the Ornstein-Uhlenbeck (OU) process for the signal. The OU process provides three properties simultaneously: (1) financially meaningful mean-reversion dynamics, empirically documented in pairs trading spreads, volatility, and interest rates (Vasicek, 1977; Gatev et al., 2006); (2) Gaussian transitions enabling exact Bellman solutions via Gauss-Hermite quadrature; (3) bounded stationary distribution ensuring numerical stability. No other common financial process provides all three.

We build on Bilokon (2026), who defines strategy-relative market regimes as filtration compressions and proves existence/uniqueness of optimal binary regime processes under Markov structure.

Contributions.

1. First verifiable RLVR environment for sequential financial planning with exact Bellman solutions.
2. Parameter landscape characterisation across 1,500 configurations identifying when planning matters.
3. Two-bucket evaluation methodology decomposing comprehension from planning.
4. Baseline evaluation showing Claude Opus 4 is statistically indistinguishable from greedy ($\rho = 0.996$, 96.5% decision overlap), with 2.9% CoT-verified planning rate.

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2. Problem Formulation

Following Bilokon (2026), the agent controls a binary regime process $s_t \in \{0, 1\}$ adapted to the filtration $(Z_0, \ldots, Z_t, s_{t-1})$, maximizing:

$$J(s) = \mathbb{E}\left[\sum_{t=0}^{T-1} u(s_t \cdot X_{t+1}) - \lambda \cdot \mathbf{1}\{s_t \neq s_{t-1}\}\right]$$

where $s_t = 1$ means the strategy is active (collect PnL), $s_t = 0$ means inactive (earn nothing), and λ is the switching cost.

The signal follows an OU process: $Z_{t+1} = Z_t + \kappa(\theta - Z_t) + \sigma_z \epsilon_t$, with PnL $X_{t+1}|Z_t \sim \mathcal{N}(\alpha Z_t, \sigma_x^2)$. The Bellman recursion is solved exactly via backward induction on a discretised z-grid with Gauss-Hermite quadrature for the Gaussian transition integral.

Each episode samples different parameters $(\kappa, \lambda, \alpha, \sigma_z, T)$ from configured ranges. The model knows α, λ, T (given in the prompt) but not κ or σ_z (must infer from observations). The Bellman solver knows all parameters — creating an information asymmetry discussed in Section 6.

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3. Gym Architecture

Generator: Samples parameters, simulates OU trajectory, solves Bellman exactly, returns fully-solved problem instance.

Verifier: Parses LLM decisions from multi-turn text, computes realised payoff J_{LLM}, returns regret-normalised score $\frac{J_{\text{LLM}}-J_{\text{random}}}{J_{\text{optimal}}-J_{\text{random}}}$. Scores are clipped to $[-1, 2]$; degenerate instances handled via minimum-denominator threshold.

Prompt Manager: Multi-turn protocol — one signal per turn, model commits before seeing the next. Enforces the information constraint matching the Bellman solution's filtration.

Integration: Single function `reward_fn(completions, problems) $\to$ list[float]` compatible with TRL/veRL GRPO trainers.

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4. Parameter Landscape Analysis

Full factorial sweep: $5\kappa \times 5\lambda \times 5\alpha \times 3\sigma_z \times 4T = 1{,}500$ configurations, each solved exactly. The **solver-based disagreement metric** measures the fraction of states where optimal and greedy policies differ, weighted by the OU stationary distribution.

Key findings:

Parameter	Effect
κ (persistence)	**Dominant.** $\kappa = 0.1$: 13.1% avg disagreement. $\kappa = 0.7$: 1.2%.
λ/α ratio	Non-monotone, peaks at 0.33–0.50.
T (horizon)	Moderate amplifier.
σ_z, α	Small individual effects.

Maximum disagreement: approximately 22% of states on the grid, approximately 10% on actual trajectories (the difference arises because the stationary distribution concentrates probability away from the disagreement zone). See Figure A.

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5. The Planning Mechanism

The greedy agent switches ON when $\alpha z > \lambda$ (immediate gain exceeds cost), giving threshold $z > \lambda/\alpha = 0.50$ at our evaluation configuration. The optimal agent switches ON at $z > 0.22$ — more aggressive because it amortises the one-time switching cost over persistent future gains. This was verified by direct Q-value computation from the Bellman table.

The **disagreement zone** $z \in [0.22, 0.50]$ (for OFF→ON) is where planning changes the decision. At the terminal step, optimal reduces to greedy exactly (no future). The zone widens backward in time. Both policies exhibit hysteresis: ON→OFF thresholds are symmetric around zero.

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6. LLM Evaluation

6.1 Setup

Claude Opus 4, 30 instances, $\kappa = 0.1$, $\lambda = 0.15$, $\alpha = 0.30$, $T = 25$. Total: 750 decisions (682 easy, 68 hard). Multi-turn (25 API calls per instance). All results use the corrected parser; raw text of all 750 responses is archived.

6.2 Two-Bucket Results

Bucket	Decisions	Opus accuracy	Interpretation
Easy (greedy = optimal)	682	99.3% (677/682)	Near-perfect comprehension
Hard (greedy $\neq$ optimal)	68	5.9% (4/68)	Near-zero planning

On hard decisions: 94.1% match greedy, 5.9% match optimal, 0% match neither.

6.3 CoT Verification

Manual inspection of all 68 hard decisions from saved raw text:

- **2/68 genuine planning** (2.9%): Model explicitly cited signal trend, remaining horizon, and amortisation logic.
  - *Seed 14, t=2*: "increasing positive momentum... 23 steps remaining... expected value of switching ON is positive"
  - *Seed 28, t=13*: "missed 0.25 in potential profits exceeds switching cost... 12 steps remaining"
- **2/68 borderline** (2.9%): Near-threshold arithmetic, unclear if planning or rounding.
- **64/68 greedy** (94.1%): No forward-looking reasoning in CoT.

Notable: At seed 28, t=12 (one step before the genuine planning instance), the model articulated correct planning logic — then chose greedy anyway: *"this is a very strong signal... With 13 more steps remaining... switching ON could be profitable... s_t = 0."* The model can produce the reasoning but cannot act on it.

6.4 Aggregate Comparison

Agent	Mean J	Decision overlap with Greedy
Optimal	+1.30	79.6%
Greedy	+1.19	100% (reference)
Opus	**+1.17**	**96.5%**
Random	\$-\$1.81	—

Opus–Greedy correlation: $\rho = 0.996$. Two-sample t-test: $p = 0.97$ (not significant). **Opus is statistically indistinguishable from Greedy on aggregate profit.** The 96.5% decision overlap and near-identical J confirm that the model applies the same myopic cost-benefit framework as greedy, despite having signal history that could enable better decisions.

Statistical caveat: All LLM results are from $N = 30$ instances. The Opus vs Greedy comparison is not significant ($p = 0.97$); Greedy vs Optimal is also not significant ($p = 0.82$). The two-bucket analysis (per-decision, $n = 750$) provides more statistical power than aggregate J comparison ($N = 30$).

6.5 Information Asymmetry

The optimal policy knows κ; the model does not. However, hard decisions occur at median $t = 11$, where the model has observed ~11 signals — sufficient data to potentially estimate signal persistence. A controlled test ($\kappa = 0.1$ vs $\kappa = 0.7$, same $\alpha/\lambda/T$, $N = 5$ per condition) showed identical model behavior in both conditions (95.9% easy accuracy, 0.4 switches). Only 3 hard decisions occurred — inconclusive, but consistent with the model not inferring κ from data. The prompt states "maximize total profit" and imposes switching costs — logically implying that future dynamics matter. The model has the information and the objective; it does not make the inference.

7. Discussion

The single gap. Opus has near-perfect comprehension (99.3%) and near-zero planning (2.9% CoT-verified). There is one gap, not two. The model correctly evaluates immediate payoffs but cannot override myopic cost-benefit when future dynamics make it suboptimal.

Prompt scaffolding. A scaffolded prompt (pre-computed options, trend highlighting, persistence hints) achieved 100% on one instance including its hard decision. But the scaffold performed the planning for the model. The model followed instructions; it did not plan. This confirms the capability is latent — the model can execute planning logic when told what to compute, but cannot construct the reasoning scaffold independently.

Implications for RLVR. The gym's multi-step objective and switching costs logically require forward-looking reasoning — the prompt says so. The model has signal history from which dynamics could be inferred. Yet it applies step-by-step cost-benefit on 94% of hard decisions. RLVR training would provide gradient pushing the model to: (1) attend to signal history, (2) estimate persistence, (3) override the immediate cost-benefit when amortisation justifies it. The 2 genuine planning instances prove this reasoning exists in the model's distribution.

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8. Limitations

Single problem type. Binary switching on a scalar OU signal. The binary action space is the paper's thesis (Bilokon 2026 proves one bit suffices as a filtration compression), not a simplification. However, extending to different PnL functions on the same signal (mean-reversion profit, momentum, magnitude) would test different temporal reasoning sub-skills within the same framework — this is planned but not yet implemented.

Information asymmetry. The Bellman solver knows κ; the model does not. This is discussed in Section 6.5: hard decisions at $t = 11$ (median) give the model sufficient history to potentially infer κ, and the prompt's multi-step objective logically implies dynamics matter. A POMDP formulation (where the optimal also infers κ) would make the comparison strictly fair.

Single model. Only Opus evaluated with corrected parser. Other models tested with broken parser only (results excluded).

Small N for aggregate statistics. At $N = 30$: Opus vs Greedy ($p = 0.97$) and Greedy vs Optimal ($p = 0.82$) are not significant on aggregate J. The two-bucket per-decision analysis ($n = 750$) provides the statistical power; aggregate J does not.

No training results. We provide the gym and baseline. RLVR training has not been conducted.

Stationary process. The OU process is time-homogeneous. Real markets are non-stationary.

Parser bug. Initial results (Easy 77.4%, Hard 4.8%) were wrong due to a parser that failed to match `s_t = 1` format. Discovered through CoT inspection. All results in this paper use the corrected parser; raw text archived for verification. Lesson: parser correctness must be validated against ground-truth responses before reporting.

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9. Conclusion

We presented the first verifiable RLVR environment for sequential financial planning. The OU process provides exact Bellman solutions via Gauss-Hermite quadrature, bypassing the unknown-distribution obstacle of real markets. The parameter landscape (1,500 configurations) fully characterises where planning matters.

Claude Opus 4 is statistically indistinguishable from a greedy baseline ($\rho = 0.996$, $p = 0.97$, 96.5% decision overlap). On the 68 decisions where planning matters, the model follows greedy 94.1% of the time. CoT inspection confirms genuine forward-looking reasoning in 2.9% of hard decisions — the capability exists in traces but is

not the model's default behavior. The model has the information (signal history), the objective (maximize total profit), and the logical framework (switching costs imply future matters) to plan. It does not.

The gym provides: exact verification, a diagnostic methodology (two-bucket + CoT), and a concrete baseline. One function integrates it into any GRPO pipeline.

References

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Appendix

A. Verified Numbers

All numbers verified against `eval_opus_buckets_v2.json` (corrected parser, raw text archived) and `full_parameter_sweep.j` (solver-based, 1,500 configs).

Claim in paper	Verified value	Source
1,500 configs	1,500	full_parameter_sweep.json
682 easy, 68 hard	682, 68	eval_opus_buckets_v2.json
Easy 99.3%	99.3% (677/682)	eval_opus_buckets_v2.json
Hard 5.9%	5.9% (4/68)	eval_opus_buckets_v2.json
$\kappa = 0.1$ avg 13.1%	13.1%	full_parameter_sweep.json
$\kappa = 0.7$ avg 1.2%	1.2%	full_parameter_sweep.json
Max disagreement approximately 22%	22.0%	full_parameter_sweep.json
Optimal threshold approximately 0.22	0.216	Bellman solver
Mean J Optimal +1.30	+1.30	Recomputed from v2 instances
Mean J Greedy +1.19	+1.19	Recomputed from v2 instances
Mean J Opus +1.17	+1.17	Recomputed from v2 instances
Mean J Random \$-\$1.81	\$-\$1.81	Recomputed from v2 instances
Opus–Greedy ρ	0.996	Recomputed
Opus–Greedy overlap	96.5%	Recomputed
Opus vs Greedy p	0.97	Two-sample t-test, $N = 30$
Greedy vs Optimal p	0.82	Two-sample t-test, $N = 30$

B. The Two Genuine Planning Instances (full text)

Seed 14, t=2 (Z=+0.31, greedy=OFF, optimal=ON, model=ON):

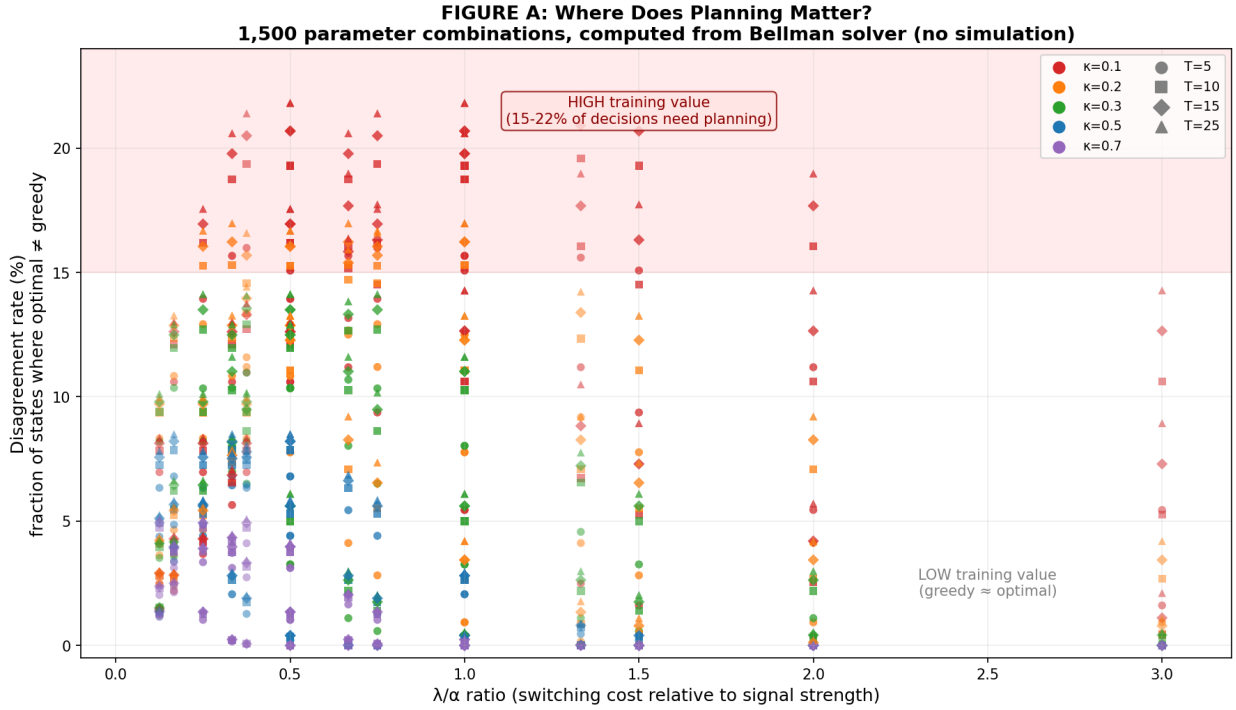


Figure 1: Figure A — Where Planning Matters (1,500 configs, solver-based)

> "This is a much stronger signal. The immediate PnL of 0.09264 alone covers about 62% of the switching cost. We're still early in the trading period (t=2 out of 25), giving plenty of time to accumulate additional profits if I stay ON. Looking at the pattern: Z_0 = +0.0148, Z_1 = +0.1157, Z_2 = +0.3088 shows increasing positive momentum. With 23 steps remaining and a strong current signal, the expected value of switching ON is positive."

Seed 28, t=13 (Z=+0.40, greedy=OFF, optimal=ON, model=ON):

> "I've now seen two consecutive very strong positive signals: t=12: +0.4546 (would have earned 0.13638), t=13: +0.3960 (would earn 0.1188). By staying OFF, I've missed 0.13638 + 0.1188 = 0.25518 in potential profits. This exceeds the switching cost of 0.1500. With 12 steps remaining and evidence of strong positive signals, I should switch"

C. Figures

D. Complete Test Summary

#	Test	Prompt	N	Key Result	Confidence
1	Solver: T=1 = greedy	N/A	All grid	Exact match	High
2	Goldilocks (3 levels)	N/A	500 ea	PASS	High
3	Parameter sweep	N/A	1,500	κ dominant	High
4	T=1 accuracy, old prompt	OLD	10	approximately 20%	High
5	T=1 accuracy, improved	IMPROVED	10	approximately 80%	High
6	**Main eval (corrected)**	**IMPROVED**	**30 (750 dec)**	**Easy 99.3%, Hard 5.9%**	**High**
7	Scaffolded test	SCAFFOLD	1	25/25 (scaffold planned)	Medium
8	Manual minimal	IMPROVED	1	9/9 easy, 0/1 hard	Medium
9	κ inference	IMPROVED	5+5	Identical behavior, 3 hard	Low

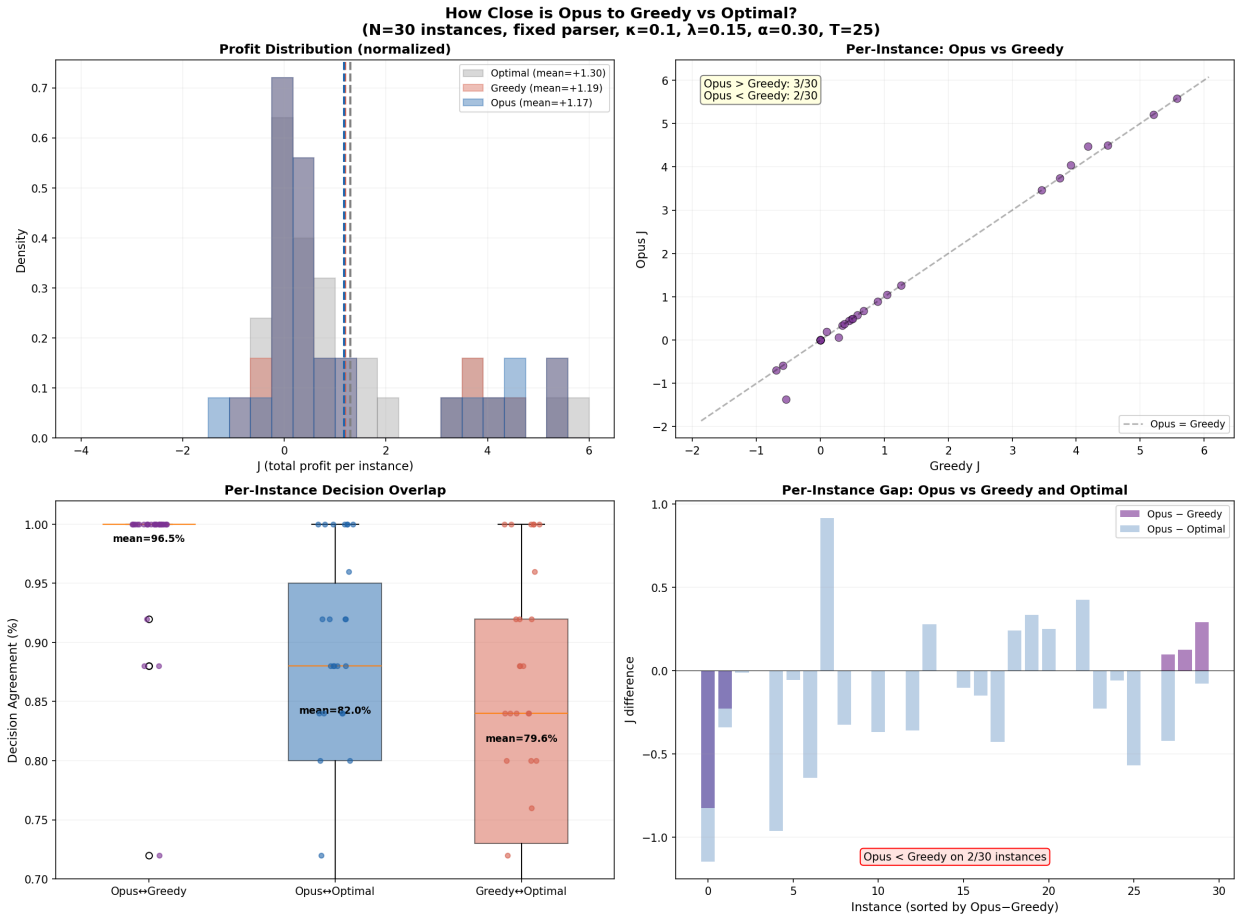


Figure 2: Figure B — Opus vs Greedy vs Optimal distributions

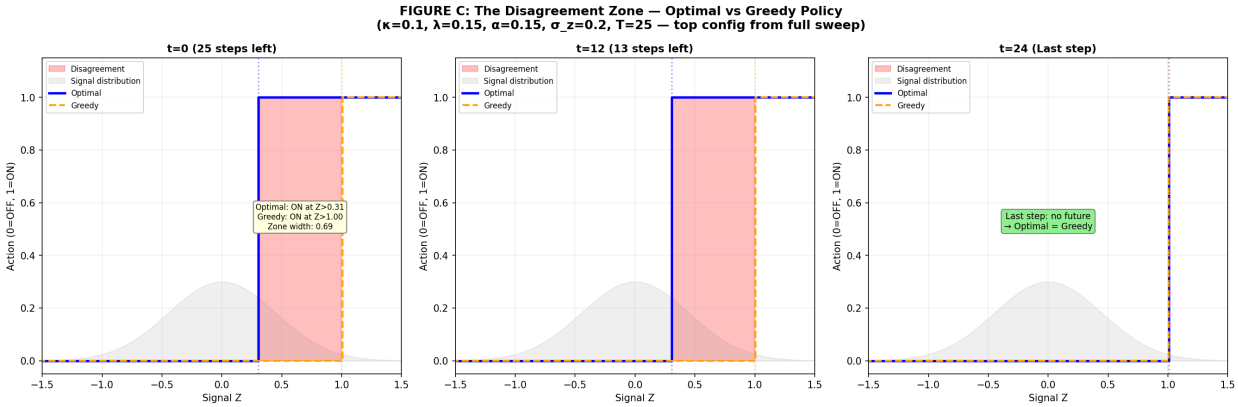


Figure 3: Figure C — The Disagreement Zone (3 time steps)

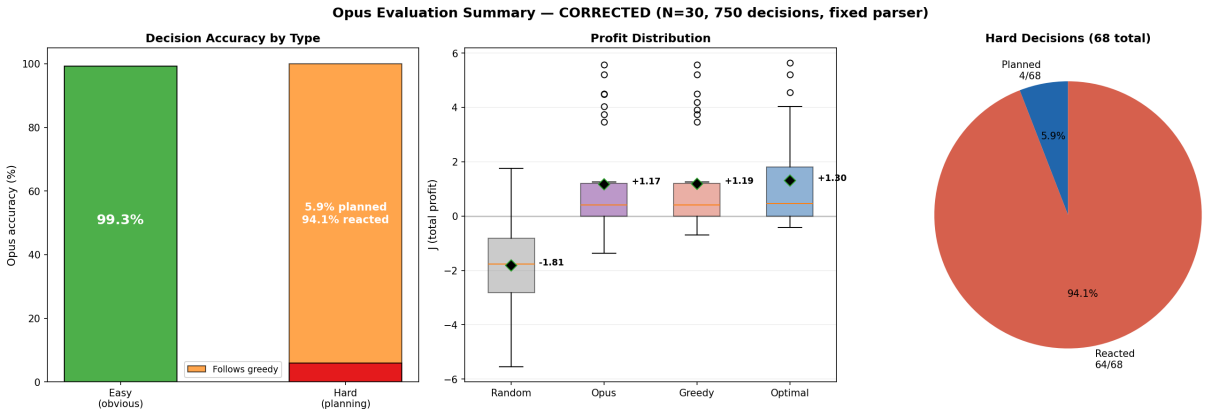


Figure 4: Figure D — Opus Evaluation Summary

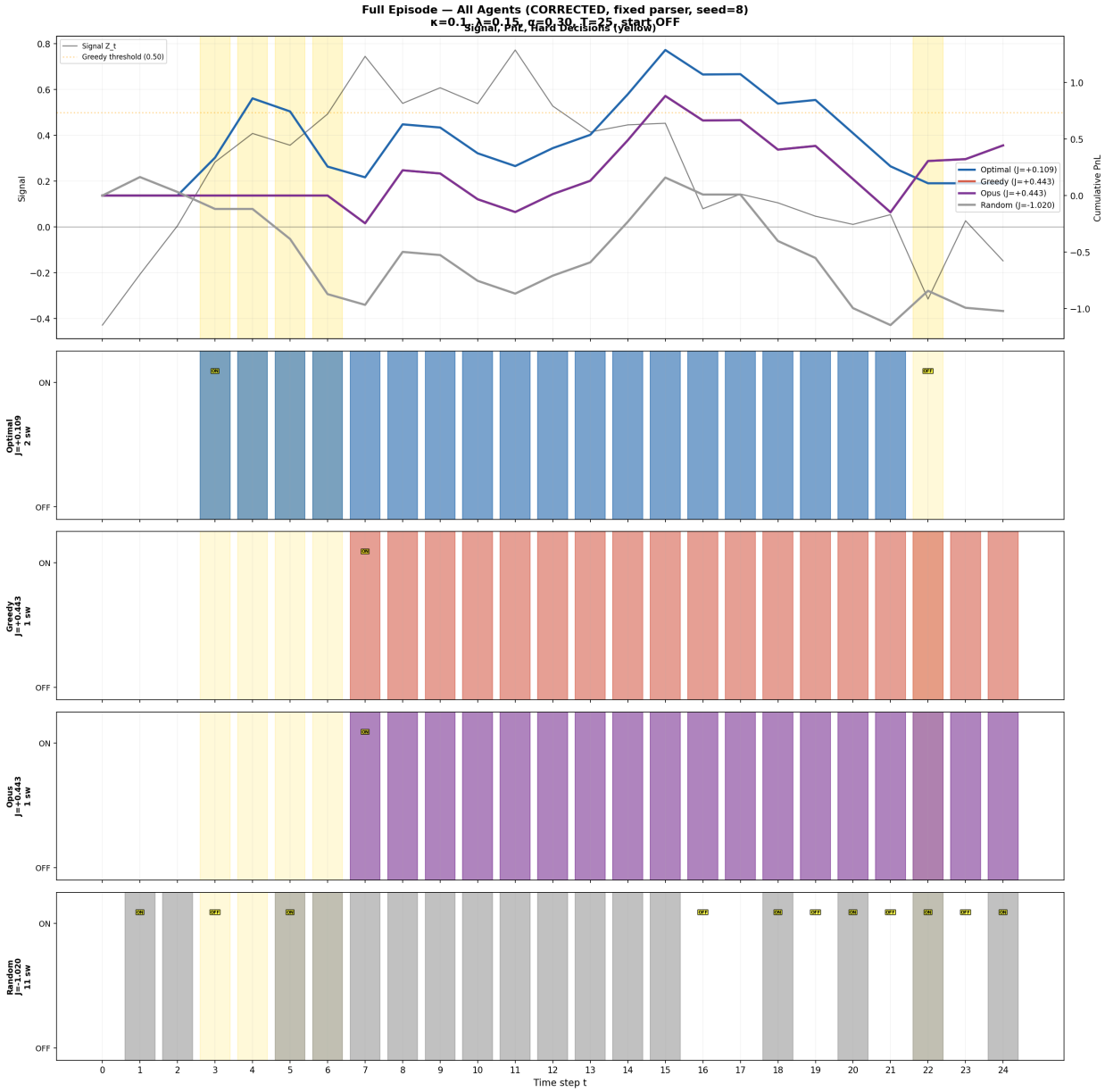


Figure 5: Figure E — Full Episode (seed 8, Opus alternating)

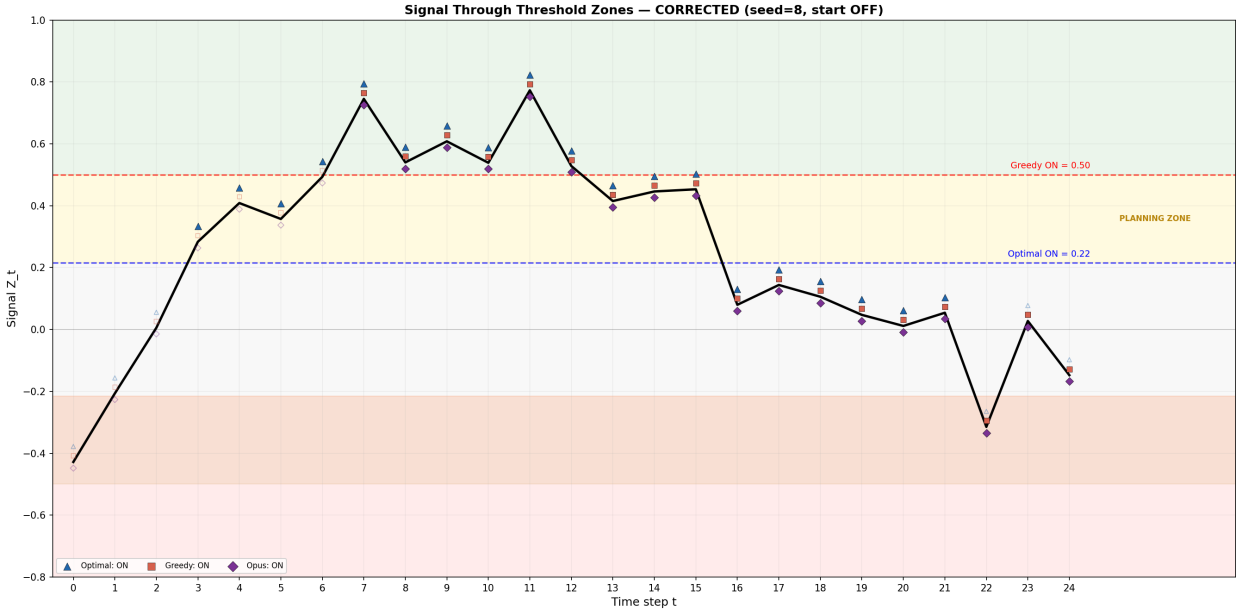
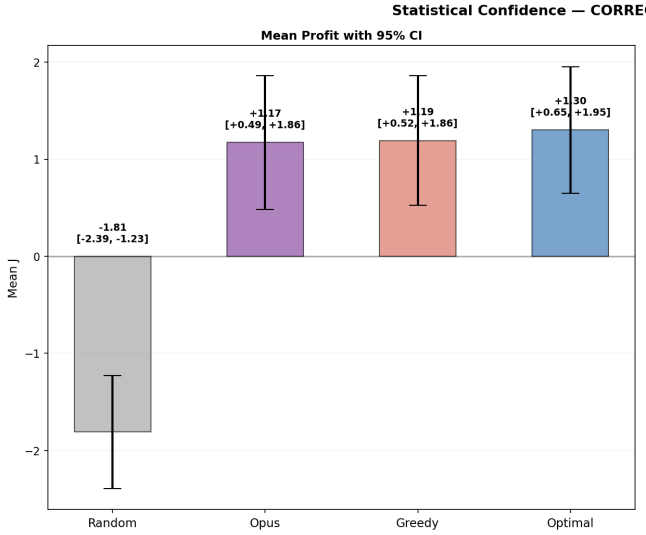


Figure 6: Figure F — Signal Through Threshold Zones



Statistical Tests (corrected)

Comparison	Mean diff	t-stat	p-value	Significant?
Opus vs Random	+2.984	6.49	0.0000	YES
Opus vs Greedy	-0.018	-0.04	0.9708	no
Opus vs Optimal	-0.127	-0.26	0.7936	no
Greedy vs Optimal	-0.109	-0.23	0.8195	no
CORRECTED RESULTS				
Easy accuracy	99.3%	677/682		
Hard: plans	5.9%	4/68		
Hard: greedy	94.1%	64/68		
CoT-verified	2.9%	2/68		

Figure 7: Figure G — Statistical Confidence